

Your 20-week scan

This second-trimester ultrasound, typically done between 18–22 weeks, looks in detail at how your baby’s major organs and body systems have developed, as well as checks the placenta and the volume of the amniotic fluid.

What the scan reveals

This scan will be done between 18 and 22 weeks. By this time, your baby’s organs and body systems are well developed and can be seen clearly on an ultrasound scan. The sonographer performing the scan will look closely at how your baby’s major organs and body systems have formed and whether there are any indications of a problem (see [The ultrasound](#)). In the majority of cases, the scan will reassure women that their baby is developing normally.

If your baby is found to have a problem, the sonographer will refer you to a maternal medicine expert who will confirm the findings and offer follow-up ultrasound scans throughout the rest of your pregnancy. She will also talk to a pediatrician to make sure that they have enough information to take care of your baby at birth.

Your due date

If you had a scan in the first trimester, your dates are unlikely to be changed after a second-trimester scan. This is because dating is most accurate in early pregnancy when all babies essentially grow at the same rate. Later on, individual differences in growth start to appear, making it harder to tell if your baby is just big for gestational age or if you are further along than thought.

However, if you didn’t have a first- trimester ultrasound, the sonographer may change your dates if your baby is 10–14 days smaller or larger than expected. If your dates have been confirmed by a first-trimester scan, a substantial lag may be a sign of a growth problem (see [Growth charts](#)), although this is rare at this early gestation.

Measuring your baby Because your whole baby no longer fits on the screen, the crown–rump length won’t be measured. Instead, your baby’s size will be calculated by combining a series of measurements in a mathematical formula. The sonographer will measure the width (biparietal diameter) and circumference of your baby’s head, the circumference of your baby’s tummy (abdominal circumference), and the length of your baby’s upper leg bone (femur length). These measurements help estimate the size of your baby and check that this is within the normal range for this stage of pregnancy.

Placenta and amniotic fluid